INSTRUCTIONAL DESIGN CASE STUDY

Keep Your Cool

A Customer De-Escalation Simulation

A branching scenario for customer service training | Articulate Storyline 360

Developer	Trina
Tool	Articulate Storyline 360 (Trial)
Audience	New customer service representatives
Slides	12 slides | branching scenario
Completed	July 2026

1. Summary

New customer service reps often learn de-escalation skills reactively — by making mistakes on live calls. I designed and built a 12-slide branching scenario that lets reps practice recognizing frustration, choosing techniques, leading with empathy, and resolving issues in a safe, scored environment, including a native drag-and-drop matching activity and a conditional, variable-driven results screen.

Process

- Analysis: Defined the audience (new hires, low call-handling confidence, LMS self-paced context) and the performance gap between policy knowledge and real-time application.
- Design: Chose a branching scenario over a linear course because the target skill — reading a live conversation and adapting in the moment — only transfers through decision-making practice, not information recall. Anchored the story on one realistic customer (Sam) with a two-strike delivery failure.
- Development: Built entirely in Storyline 360's trial, using four custom variables, conditional triggers, layered coaching feedback with unlimited retries, a native Freeform Drag-and-Drop question, and a scored, condition-driven Results screen — no JavaScript.
- Testing & Iteration: A full click-through QA pass (deliberately choosing every wrong option before correcting, and testing every score range) surfaced two real issues that reshaped the final build — detailed below.

Key Design Decisions

- Severity-based branching, not uniform branching: only 2 of the 4 decision points (Slides 5 and 7) can permanently cost the learner points — those two represent 'deflecting or minimizing' responses and route through a dedicated consequence scene (Slide 8) before rejoining the main path. The other two decisions (Slides 3 and 9) are fully recoverable through same-slide coaching and unlimited retry. This means the achievable score range is narrower than originally planned (20–40 rather than a full 0–

40), which was a deliberate trade-off, not an oversight — it keeps 'recoverable mistake' and 'genuine consequence' feeling meaningfully different to the learner, at the cost of a discrete results tier that can never be reached.

- Answer position was deliberately varied across the four decision slides late in development, once testing made clear that the correct option sitting in slot B every single time invited pattern-matching over genuine reading. Slides 7 and 9 were revised so the correct answer appears in different slots.
- No negative marking, in the end: the original plan penalized wrong answers (−5) as well as rewarding correct ones (+10). During QA, an unexplained score inflation bug surfaced. Rather than let a hard-to-trace bug block the project, I simplified the scoring model to 0-for-incorrect / +10-for-correct — a smaller, more defensible model that also happened to make the eventual root cause (see below) easier to isolate.

The Debugging Story

The most valuable part of this build wasn't the design — it was tracking down a scoring bug where the final score came in higher than any combination of decisions should have allowed. I worked through it systematically: first ruling out the retry/coaching-layer triggers (checked each one individually), then the transition slides' Continue buttons, before finally isolating it to Storyline's Freeform Drag-and-Drop question, which has its own built-in point-scoring system running independently of any custom variable. Because I'd named my custom variable 'Score' and left the native question's default point value active, both systems were quietly contributing to the final number without my triggers ever being at fault. Zeroing out the native question's point value fixed it. It was a genuinely useful lesson in checking a tool's built-in behavior, not just the triggers I explicitly wrote.

Results

Delivered as a complete, fully tested Storyline 360 project — a full storyboard, a real as-built trigger/variable map, and a documented set of known limitations, suitable for both direct portfolio demonstration and as a talking point in an interview about branching-scenario design and debugging process.

Reflection

This project taught me to distinguish between a flaw and a documented trade-off. The unreachable Low-score ring — and, discovered after publishing, the Empathy Note layer that can never display for the same underlying reason — aren't things I'd hide in an interview. Both trace back to the same root cause: a decision slide with no bypass path guarantees its variable lands on one value for every learner. I'd rather explain that pattern clearly than quietly rebuild around it after the fact. That kind of reasoning, not a flawless build, is what I think actually demonstrates instructional design judgment.

End of Case Study — Keep Your Cool: A Customer De-Escalation Simulation | Portfolio Project